

# New Website — Planning Guide

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**Purpose:** How to write a site plan and what to provide (written spec, JPG mockups, phases) when building a **new** database-driven website—similar in *approach* to a Laravel catalog/member/admin site, but with its own scope, images, and data.

**Save as PDF:** Open this file in a browser → Print → Save as PDF (or use the companion `NEW_SITE_PLANNING_GUIDE.pdf` if already generated).

**This guide is not tied to MiniLicensePlates.com.** Use it for any new project folder and database. You may still borrow patterns from an existing site (catalog, search, members, admin CMS, static pages, articles, videos).

## 1. Two things to prepare

1. **Written site plan** — what the site does, data model, URLs, admin modules, phases.
2. **Visual mockups** — flattened JPG files from Photoshop showing key screens (very helpful for CSS and layout).

Together they reduce guesswork and rework. Either one alone works; both together work best.

## 2. Where to put files on your PC

| Item                    | Suggested location                                                                                |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Master written plan     | <code>docs/SITE_PLAN.md</code> in the <b>new</b> project root                                     |
| Mockup JPGs             | <code>docs/mockups/</code> (e.g. <code>home-desktop.jpg</code> , <code>search-mobile.jpg</code> ) |
| Design notes (optional) | <code>docs/design-notes.txt</code> — hex colors, font names, spacing notes                        |
| This guide              | <code>docs/NEW_SITE_PLANNING_GUIDE.pdf</code>                                                     |

## 3. Written site plan — recommended outline

Copy the sections below into `docs/SITE_PLAN.md` and fill them in. Well-structured text beats a long unstructured brain dump.

### A. Vision (about half a page)

- Who the site is for and what “done” looks like (one paragraph).
- **Non-goals** — what you are *not* building in version 1 (e.g. no shop, no comments).

### B. Stack and constraints (bullet list)

- Framework (e.g. Laravel), database (e.g. MySQL), hosting style (app folder + public web root).
- Commit/deploy rules, folders not in git, email/contact behavior.

### C. User roles

| Role    | Can do |
|---------|--------|
| Visitor | ...    |
| Member  | ...    |
| Admin   | ...    |

### D. Site map (every public and admin URL)

| URL        | Type           | Data source   | Notes |
|------------|----------------|---------------|-------|
| /          | Home           | DB / static   | ...   |
| /search    | Search results | catalog table | ...   |
| /articles  | Articles       | new table     | ...   |
| /admin/... | CMS            | auth          | ...   |

### E. Data model (one subsection per entity)

For each entity: table name, columns, relationships, who edits it (admin / member / CSV import).  
Examples: catalog items, sets/categories, members, articles, videos, site pages.

### F. Admin CMS (one subsection per module)

| Module   | Screens                  | Priority (P0/P1/P2) |
|----------|--------------------------|---------------------|
| Catalog  | sets, items, CSV import  | P0                  |
| Articles | list, add, edit, publish | P1                  |
| Videos   | embed vs upload — decide | P1                  |
| Members  | accounts, block, roles   | ...                 |

### G. Public UX (short)

- Search: which fields, sort order, page size.
- Member features: public vs private, what appears on profiles.
- Articles/videos: layout; links to catalog if any.

### H. Media and files

- Image folders under `public/`, naming rules, max upload size.
- Video: YouTube/Vimeo embed only, or files on server.
- Article body: plain HTML from CMS vs Markdown.

## I. Phases (build in order)

| Phase | Scope                                    | Done when |
|-------|------------------------------------------|-----------|
| 1     | Core catalog + search + one admin module | ...       |
| 2     | Members + collections                    | ...       |
| 3     | Articles, videos, extra CMS              | ...       |

Ask to implement **one phase at a time**, not the entire plan in one step.

## J. Open questions

List undecided items. Tell your assistant whether to ask you or use judgment only if you explicitly allow it.

## 4. How long a written plan can be

| Size                            | Typical use                                            |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 2–4 pages, structured           | Easy to plan in one conversation; build phase by phase |
| 8–15 pages in docs/SITE_PLAN.md | Good for work across many sessions                     |
| Very long unstructured text     | Split into sections or phases; harder to follow        |

### Tips so builders and AI assistants read it correctly

- Mark priority: **P0** (must have), **P1**, **P2**.
- Label each feature **new** vs **extends existing pattern**.
- One source of truth per topic (avoid repeating the same column list in three places).
- Say what **not** to change on reference sites.

## 5. What to borrow from a “similar” reference site (architecture only)

Without copying its data or images, you can reuse these *shapes*:

- Laravel + MySQL + Blade views
- Public site + member login + admin CMS behind auth
- Catalog stored in DB; images on disk; paths in database
- Search with filters; admin list / edit / delete per content type
- Optional CSV bulk import with downloadable template
- Deploy: application folder + public web root (e.g. `laravel` + `public_html`)

Define **your** tables, labels, and URLs fresh in `SITE_PLAN.md`.

## 6. Photoshop JPG mockups — why they help

Flattened JPG exports are excellent for **CSS and page layout** when you want the live site to match your design.

### Mockups help with

| Detail            | Use in build                                                   |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Layout            | Widths, header, grids, sidebars                                |
| Spacing           | Padding, gaps, button size                                     |
| Typography        | Relative sizes for titles vs body                              |
| Colors            | Backgrounds, borders, buttons (list hex codes in design-notes) |
| Components        | Cards, tables, forms, navigation                               |
| Mobile vs desktop | Separate JPGs per breakpoint if possible                       |

### Mockups do not replace

- **Real text in HTML** — body copy should not live only inside JPGs on the live site.
- **Behavior** — hover, errors, empty states, login; add notes or extra mockups.
- **Long real data** — labels that fit in Photoshop may wrap differently with live content; CSS should flex.
- **Font files** — name the font family in design-notes; JPG does not install fonts.

### How to organize mockup files

1. One JPG per screen (e.g. home, search results, item detail, member page, admin list).
2. Clear file names: `home-desktop.jpg`, `search-results-mobile.jpg`.
3. Short caption per image: “Home, logged out” / “Admin — edit article.”
4. Optional `design-notes.txt`: hex colors, font names, “content max width 900px.”
5. Artboards at realistic width (e.g. 1200px content) so proportions stay true.

You do not need to hand off `.psd` files for CSS work unless someone is slicing assets; JPG + exported logos/icons is usually enough.

## 7. Sample message to an AI coding assistant

When you start building, use a short message like this (adjust paths and phase):

```
Read docs/SITE_PLAN.md in [project folder].
Read mockups in docs/mockups/ for layout.

Implement Phase 1 only: [title].
```

Match the JPGs for CSS on Phase 1 screens.  
Stack: Laravel, MySQL, Blade.  
Do not commit. Do not deploy unless I ask.

## 8. Minimal “concept brief” before the full plan

If the full plan is not ready, start with one page answering:

- Site topic and audience (one paragraph)
- What one main “record” is (catalog item, article, etc.)
- Why members sign up
- Top five admin CMS areas you need
- How articles and videos relate to the catalog (or stand alone)
- How this site differs from your reference site in one sentence

From that, you or an assistant can draft the full `SITE_PLAN.md` skeleton.

## 9. Checklist before asking for implementation

- `docs/SITE_PLAN.md` filled in (at least Phase 1)
- Mockup JPGs for Phase 1 screens in `docs/mockups/`
- Priorities marked P0 / P1 / P2
- New project folder named; not mixed with another live site’s database
- Decisions noted: video embed vs upload; static Blade pages vs CMS pages

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Document: `NEW_SITE_PLANNING_GUIDE` — created for project planning on D: drive.

HTML source: `docs/NEW_SITE_PLANNING_GUIDE.html` — print to PDF anytime from your browser (Ctrl+P → Save as PDF).